

Iceland



Area 39,768 sq miles
(103,000 sq km)

Population 300,000

Capital Reykjavík

Currency Icelandic krona

Official language Icelandic

Life expectancy 81 years



Lying just south of the Arctic Circle in the North Atlantic Ocean, Iceland is a former Danish possession that became fully independent in 1944. It is a small volcanic island, with many glaciers, volcanoes, and geysers. The country produces cheap geothermal power, which meets almost all of its electricity and domestic heating needs. Icelanders are of Scandinavian descent and more than half the population lives in or near the capital city of Reykjavík. In July, the warmest month of the year, temperatures average around 50–55 °F (10–13 °C).

Sweden



Area 173,732 sq miles
(449,964 sq km)

Population 9.4 million

Capital Stockholm

Currency Swedish krona

Official language Swedish

Life expectancy 81 years



Situated in the east of the Scandinavian peninsula, Sweden is a densely forested country with many lakes. A constitutional monarchy, Sweden has a monarch and an elected parliament that is led by a prime minister. It has one of the largest welfare systems in the world, with all Swedes having access to publicly funded childcare, health care, schooling, and care for the elderly.

► NORTHERN LIGHTS

The Aurora borealis, or Northern Lights, is a natural light display that can be seen in northern Sweden, as well as other Arctic regions. The bright green or red lights are caused by the collision of charged particles high in Earth's atmosphere.

Norway



Area 125,182 sq miles
(324,220 sq km)

Population 4.9 million

Capital Oslo

Currency Norwegian krone

Official language Norwegian

Life expectancy 80 years



The Kingdom of Norway occupies the western part of Scandinavia, between Sweden to its east and the Norwegian Sea to its west. Norway is a constitutional monarchy, which means it has a monarch as the head of state and an elected parliament. Norwegian society has social and economic equality, but living here is costly—Oslo, its capital, is one of the world's most expensive cities. Norway was one of the first countries to grant women the vote, in 1913, and Gro Harlem Brundtland was Norway's first woman prime minister in 1990.

▼ THE OSEBERG SHIP

This Viking ship was excavated in 1904 from the Oseberg farm in Vestfold County, Norway. A burial vessel built of oak and dating from around 800 CE, it contained the skeletal remains of two women, along with personal items.

